

Pratima Barwa, the coach who gave wings to Adivasi hockey players

Chances are that most outside the **modest** Indian hockey universe would not have heard of Pratima Barwa. **Perhaps** she preferred it that way. **Barwa**, who **passed away** on Sunday aged 44 due to a brain haemorrhage, **dedicated** her life to hockey. She did what few could — identify and **nurture** young talents in one of the sport's biggest **catchment areas**, Jharkhand's Simdega. Because of her efforts, Indian hockey is in a better place — **three players**, including captain Salima Tete, **are** currently part of the national team that is in Europe for the FIH Pro League.

Grassroots coaching is one of the most **unglamorous** parts of sport because of the lack of incentive. Yet, without such coaches, the sporting **ecosystem** would be a non-starter. Selfless **coaches** like Barwa, who was from Khunti, **have** kept Indian hockey running. Her academy was **rudimentary**, and some of the coaching methods were, possibly, **archaic**. But **Barwa**, described as a “mother figure” by her wards, **did** something far more impactful — she got children **hooked** to hockey and **gave wings to their dreams**.



Barwa's own **aspirations** to play for India were unfulfilled. She played for Bihar in the early 1990s. However, a left knee ligament injury in 1995 **cut short** her playing career. She then promised herself that she would help young players from the region. Barwa's **journey** as a coach **began** in 2008 after she completed a diploma from the National Institute of Sport in Patiala. A **job** with the Jharkhand government as a coach **took** her to Simdega, and **the hard yards** began. From sunrise to sunset, she would travel to schools and villages where there was the slightest promise of talent, **convince** the families to let their child play hockey and then **groom** them into world-class talents. Barwa never got the **recognition** she deserved. Her **legacy** will, however, be there for all to see each time the Indian team steps onto the hockey field.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

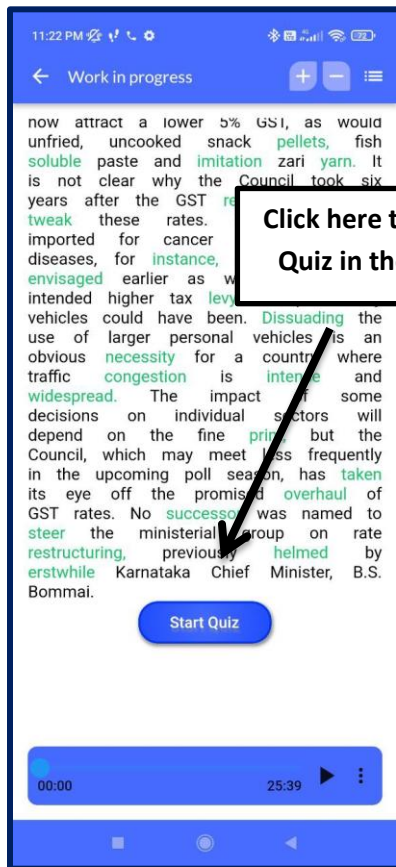
Vocabulary

1. **Modest** (adjective) – humble, unassuming, simple, moderate, unpretentious साधारण / विनम्र
2. **Perhaps** (adverb) – maybe, possibly, conceivably, potentially, perchance शायद
3. **Pass away** (phrasal verb) – die, expire, depart, perish, succumb मृत्यु होना
4. **Nurture** (verb) – foster, cultivate, support, train, encourage बढ़ावा देना
5. **Catchment area** (noun) – the area around a business, school, etc. that its customers, students, etc. come from क्षेत्र / भर्ती क्षेत्र
6. **Unglamorous** (adjective) – unattractive, unappealing, plain, humble, unrewarding गैर-आकर्षक / साधारण
7. **Ecosystem** (noun) – environment, system, structure, network, framework पारिस्थितिकी तंत्र
8. **Rudimentary** (adjective) – basic, elementary, undeveloped, crude, primitive प्रारंभिक / अधूरा
9. **Archaic** (adjective) – outdated, old-fashioned, obsolete, ancient, antiquated पुराना / प्राचीन
10. **Hook** (to) (verb) – attract, engage, captivate, interest, draw in लत लगाना / आकर्षित करना
11. **Give wings to one's dream** (phrase) – enable, empower, inspire, fulfill, support किसी के सपनों को उड़ान देना
12. **Aspiration** (noun) – ambition, goal, desire, dream, aim आकांक्षा
13. **Cut short** (phrase) – interrupt, end abruptly, stop midway, terminate early, break off बीच में रोक देना / संक्षिप्त करना
14. **The hard yards** (phrase) – effort, struggle, difficult work, perseverance, labour कठिन परिश्रम
15. **Convince** (verb) – persuade, assure, win over, influence, coax मनाना / राज़ी करना
16. **Groom** (verb) – train, prepare, develop, nurture, shape तैयार करना
17. **Recognition** (noun) – acknowledgment, appreciation, credit, acclaim, respect पहचान / सराहना
18. **Legacy** (noun) – inheritance, contribution, heritage, impact, remembrance विरासत / स्मृति

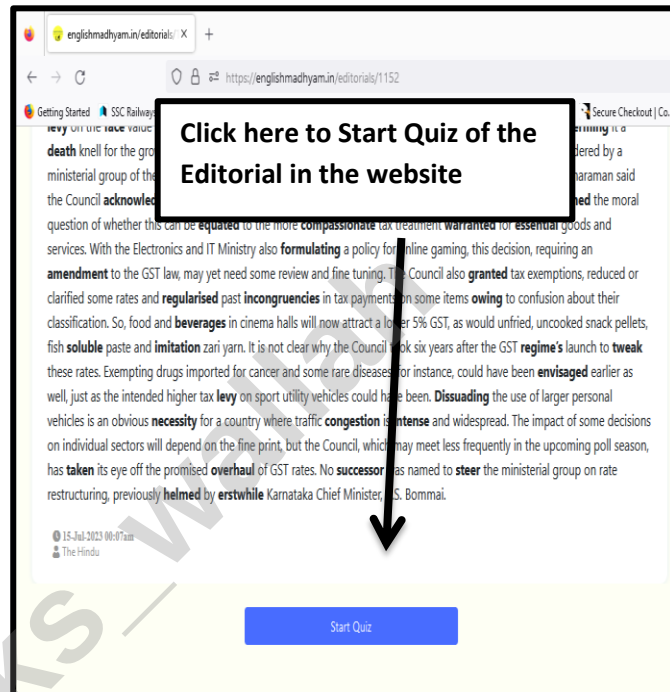
Summary of the Editorial

1. Pratima Barwa's Passing – Pratima Barwa, a grassroots hockey coach from Jharkhand, passed away at 44 due to a brain haemorrhage.
2. Unsung Hero – Despite her crucial role, Barwa remained largely unknown outside India's modest hockey circles.
3. Contribution to Indian Hockey – Her efforts nurtured several national-level players, including Indian women's team captain Salima Tete.
4. Focus Area – Simdega – Barwa worked primarily in Simdega, Jharkhand, a region rich in hockey talent.
5. Roots in Khunti – She hailed from Khunti and was deeply committed to developing Adivasi talent.
6. Unfulfilled Player Dream – Barwa played for Bihar in the early 1990s, but a knee ligament injury in 1995 ended her playing career.
7. Turn to Coaching – After her injury, she pledged to support other players' dreams through coaching.
8. Formal Training – She earned a coaching diploma in 2008 from the National Institute of Sport, Patiala.
9. Jharkhand Government Role – She joined the Jharkhand government as a coach, which led her to Simdega.
10. Grassroots Outreach – Barwa travelled village to village, school to school, identifying and convincing families to let their children play.
11. Lack of Glamour and Support – Grassroots coaching lacked recognition, infrastructure, and incentives, yet Barwa persevered selflessly.
12. Basic Training Facilities – Her coaching setup was rudimentary and possibly outdated, but highly impactful.
13. Motherly Figure – Her students described her as a "mother figure", highlighting her emotional investment in their lives.
14. Lasting Legacy – Though unrecognized in life, Barwa's legacy lives on in every Indian player she helped shape.
15. Symbol of Dedication – Barwa symbolizes dedication, resilience, and grassroots empowerment in Indian sports.

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